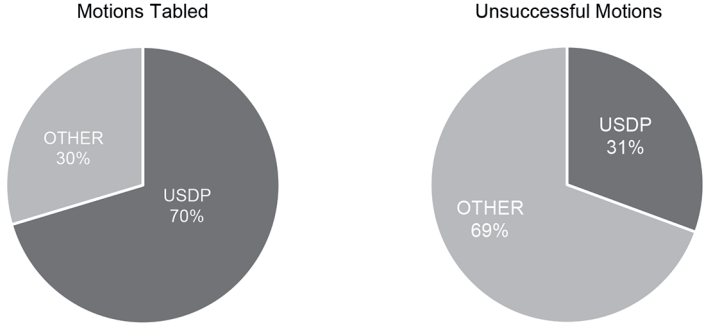
legislative motions received non-partisan support. On communal violence, the USDP party members rejected their party's own motion. In the first term of the Hluttaw, voting patterns were not based on party lines. This is because the USDP overwhelmingly controlled the Hluttaw, there was no eminent threat and in order to show the robustness and legitimacy of the Hluttaw, a non-partisan approach was encouraged. Unless it would fundamentally affect party interest, legislators were free to vote based on their own positions.[17] In some cases, legislative committee members from different parties even voted in a bloc.[18] The non-partisan nature of the legislature was relevant when dealing with the executive. However, the military supported the government's position on most issues, even when USDP lawmakers, whose own party was in power, voted against it.

Figure 10.1. represents the non-partisan nature of the legislature, taking motions as a proxy. Because of its numerical superiority, the USDP tabled more motions than non-USDP members. Despite its overwhelming control of the legislature, around one-third of motions rejected were from USDP.

Figure 10.1 Non-partisan legislature, 2011–14



The non-partisan nature of the Hluttaw can be taken as an institutional legacy of earlier parliaments. With bitter memories of the factional power struggle during the post-independence period of the 1950s and early 1960s, the new Myanmar legislature was careful not to be portrayed as divided, at least in the public eye. Furthermore, in order to legitimise the legislature, ethnic and minor parties including the opposition National League for Democracy (NLD) were represented inclusively in the legislative committees in accordance with their number of seats, even though it was